

next decade or so, but not for next generation warfare some two decades hence," says Bharadwaj.

In the meantime, the army has gone ahead and ordered an additional 330 T-90 tank kits and another 1,000 T-90s from Russia to be assembled at the IVEI, Avadi, a deal that actually saved Russia's largest tank manufacturer, Ural Vagon Zavod from shutdown. By 2020, the army hopes to field a force of over 21 regiments of T-90 tanks and 40 regiments of modified T-72s. The DRDO has been arguing for a slice of the pie—a mix of heavy tanks including the Arjun and medium tanks

The MoD is close to agreeing on a compromise—124 more Arjuns and comparative trials later this year with the T-90 and T-72.

breakeven on the project investments of around Rs 370 crore is now scrambling to integrate Arjun-2 features on the promised second batch.

The DRDO is also pressing for comparative trials of the Arjun with the T-90 known as the 'Bhishma' in the army, in Rajasthan later this year. It is a desperate rearguard action where the agency hopes to repeat mythology,

space industry has not translated into defence industry? These are matters which transcend the bean counters at service headquarters into the realm of higher national strategic planning. India already has the dubious distinction of being the

world's second largest importer of defence items, abjectly dependent on foreign suppliers who sit on the UN Security Council, where it aspires to be—to supply basics like tanks and fighter aircraft.

There are some answers under the hood of the Arjun—only the third complete defence system produced indigenously after the Akash medium-range surface-to-air missile and the Pinaka

WHY THE ARJUN IS GROUNDED

ARMY'S VIEW

- Arjun is horribly late. Should have been inducted a decade ago when Pakistan began inducting T-80s.
- Requirements changed because DRDO took time to deliver first batch of tanks
- Tank is good but relevant only for 10-15 years. We want future tanks.
- Don't want Arjun-2. Are importing over 1,600 T-90 tanks from Russia.
- DRDO should work on Future MBT design for the army



DRDO VIEW

- Development cycle and delays in productionising the tank at OFB. Army kept changing requirements.
- Army always wanted 'best in the world' systems and we had to satisfy them
- Order 376 more Arjuns, we'll give you a more sophisticated Arjun-2.
- Take the T-90s but also order 500 indigenous Arjuns
- Army yet to give us FMBT design for two years now

like the T-72 and T-90. But the army is not convinced. It has rejected the DRDO's offer of Arjun Mark-2—featuring uprated engines, digital fire control and a battlefield management system with the ability to 'talk' to other assets, which it claims it can field in five years. The army insists it wants nothing short of a futuristic tank. Yet, despite repeated reminders over the past two years, the army is yet to even furnish the DRDO its requirements.

Has the door been closed on Arjun? Not just yet. Senior Defence Ministry officials have indicated an order for a second batch of modified 124 Arjun tanks as a face-saver for the DRDO and that would be the end of the programme. "After that we want the DRDO to focus on building the FMBT."

The DRDO which says it needs an order of at least 376 more tanks to

RUSSIAN REVOLUTION: The army will buy over 1,600 T-90s in 12 years

but this is a contest the army is keen to avoid. "It's just a ploy to fool the bureaucrats," snarls a senior army official.

The army concedes that the Arjun programme was a learning experience—on how not to execute a project and the necessity for closer user-interface. "As users we did not get adequately involved in the project as say the navy does," says Shekhawat. "Army officers posted on the project reported to the DRDO and not to army HQ. In the end, the DRDO did not get honest advice," he says.

The battle over the Arjun is not just about a tank. It is about the shaky but obligatory path of building of indigenous defence capability. Why for instance, India's stunning success in the

rocket system. A raft of systems made indigenously talks about the tremendous force-multiplier effect of this programme. Its gearbox is common with the Tejas Light Combat Aircraft and indigenous gas-based suspension compares with the best in the world. Sure, nearly 60 per cent of the components of the first batch of 124 tanks, including the German-built powerpack are imported. The DRDO says these will be reduced to under 30 per cent after it builds 500 tanks.

"We are not ashamed of the delays but ashamed of the fact that we cannot sell it within our own country," says a senior DRDO scientist. An Arjun with no takers in India. That would be a tragedy of epic proportions.

Log on to www.indiatoday.in to see 'driving the Arjun'